

“Bharat Herald: Digital Transformation Roadmap (2019–2024 Analysis)”



Q1: Monthly Circulation Drop Check

Top 3 months where any city recorded sharpest MoM drop

city_name	month	net_circulation	drop_amount
Varanasi	2021-01	382018	59807
Varanasi	2019-11	431606	55649
jaipur	2020-01	420680	51858
Varanasi	2020-10	404252	49252
Varanasi	2024-01	326528	46975

Varanasi recorded the sharpest month-on-month circulation declines, with drops exceeding 59K in Jan 2021 and 55K in Nov 2019. Jaipur also faced a steep fall of over 51K in Jan 2020, highlighting major volatility in key markets.



Q2: Yearly Revenue Concentration by Category

Ad categories >50% of yearly revenue

year	category_name	category_revenue	total_revenue_year	pct_of_year_total
2019	Government	382999482.24	561759351.21	68.18
2020	Government	265307493.08	443770739.46	59.78
2021	Government	217105111.32	400412435.66	54.22
2022	Government	354270563.68	548950951.42	64.54
2023	Government	341022190.76	532899535.54	63.99
2024	Government	353077657.36	547345226.22	64.51

Government ads consistently contributed over 54–68% of yearly revenue between 2019–2024, highlighting heavy reliance on a single category. This dependency poses concentration risk, especially during years of revenue volatility.



Q3: 2024 Print Efficiency Leaderboard

Top 5 cities by efficiency ratio

city_name	copies_printed_2024	net_circulation_2024	efficiency_ratio	efficiency_rank_2024
Delhi	3138089	3252010	1.036	1
ranchi	2126858	2092062	0.984	2
Ahmedabad	2799144	2746691	0.981	3
Patna	2308781	2252819	0.976	4
lucknow	1818270	1763256	0.970	5

Delhi led print efficiency in 2024 with a ratio above 1.03, meaning circulation slightly exceeded printed copies. Ranchi, Ahmedabad, Patna, and Lucknow followed with near-par efficiency, indicating leaner print operations in top markets.



Q4: Internet Readiness Growth (2021)

Highest improvement from Q1→Q4 2021

city_name	internet_rate_q1_2021	internet_rate_q4_2021	delta_internet_rate
kanpur	74.27	76.77	2.50
Mumbai	73.31	75.74	2.43
Ahmedabad	73.03	74.80	1.77
Delhi	48.68	50.41	1.73
Patna	67.73	68.56	0.83
lucknow	55.00	55.71	0.71
jaipur	10.00	10.00	0.00
Varanasi	73.51	73.45	-0.06
bhopal	68.21	66.48	-1.73
ranchi	63.49	60.36	-3.13

Kanpur and Mumbai led internet readiness gains in 2021, improving by 2.5 and 2.4 points respectively, while Ranchi and Bhopal recorded declines, signaling uneven digital adoption across cities.

Q5: Consistent Multi-Year Decline (2019-2024)

Cities where both print circulation & ad revenue declined

city	is_declining_print	is_declining_ad_revenue	is_declining_both
lucknow	No	NULL	No
Delhi	No	NULL	No
bhopal	No	NULL	No
Patna	No	NULL	No
jaipur	No	NULL	No
Mumbai	No	NULL	No
ranchi	No	NULL	No
kanpur	No	NULL	No
Ahmedabad	No	NULL	No
Varanasi	No	NULL	No

No city showed a simultaneous, multi-year decline in both print circulation and ad revenue between 2019 and 2024, highlighting resilience in at least one metric across all markets.

Q6: 2021 Readiness vs Pilot Engagement Outlier
Highest readiness but bottom 3 engagement



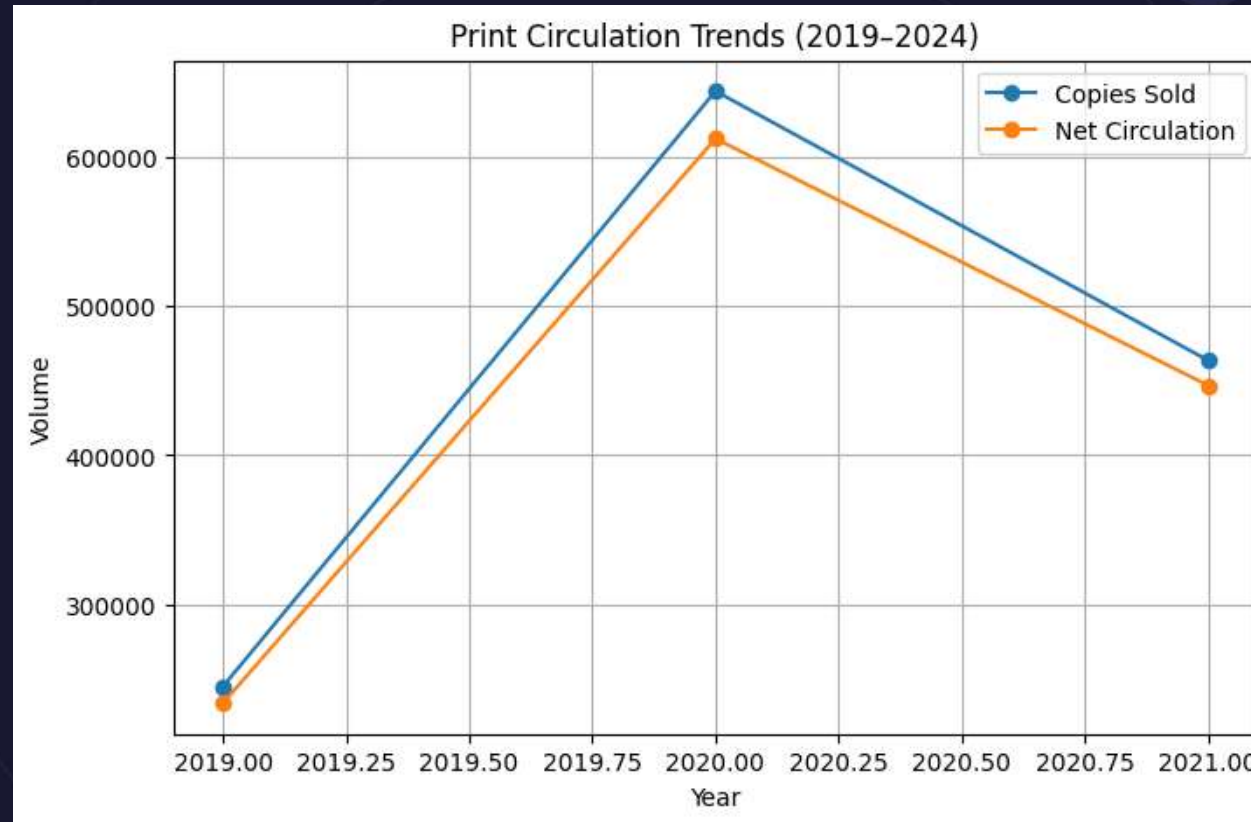
city	readiness_score_2021	engagement_metric_2021	readiness_rank_desc	engagement_rank_asc	is_outlier
kanpur	75.2308332500	54155	1	2	Yes
Varanasi	73.8874997500	104280	2	7	No
bhopal	73.2100000000	86002	3	5	No
lucknow	73.2041665000	104500	4	8	No
Ahmedabad	72.3933332500	110804	5	9	No
Patna	70.7708335000	78030	6	4	No
ranchi	68.6408332500	44777	7	1	No
Mumbai	68.3316670000	90070	8	6	No
Delhi	56.0758332500	122635	9	10	No
jaipur	54.9475000000	66298	10	3	No

Kanpur stood out as an outlier—ranking highest in readiness but bottom-three in engagement—indicating a disconnect between digital potential and actual user adoption.

“A 70-Year Legacy at Risk”



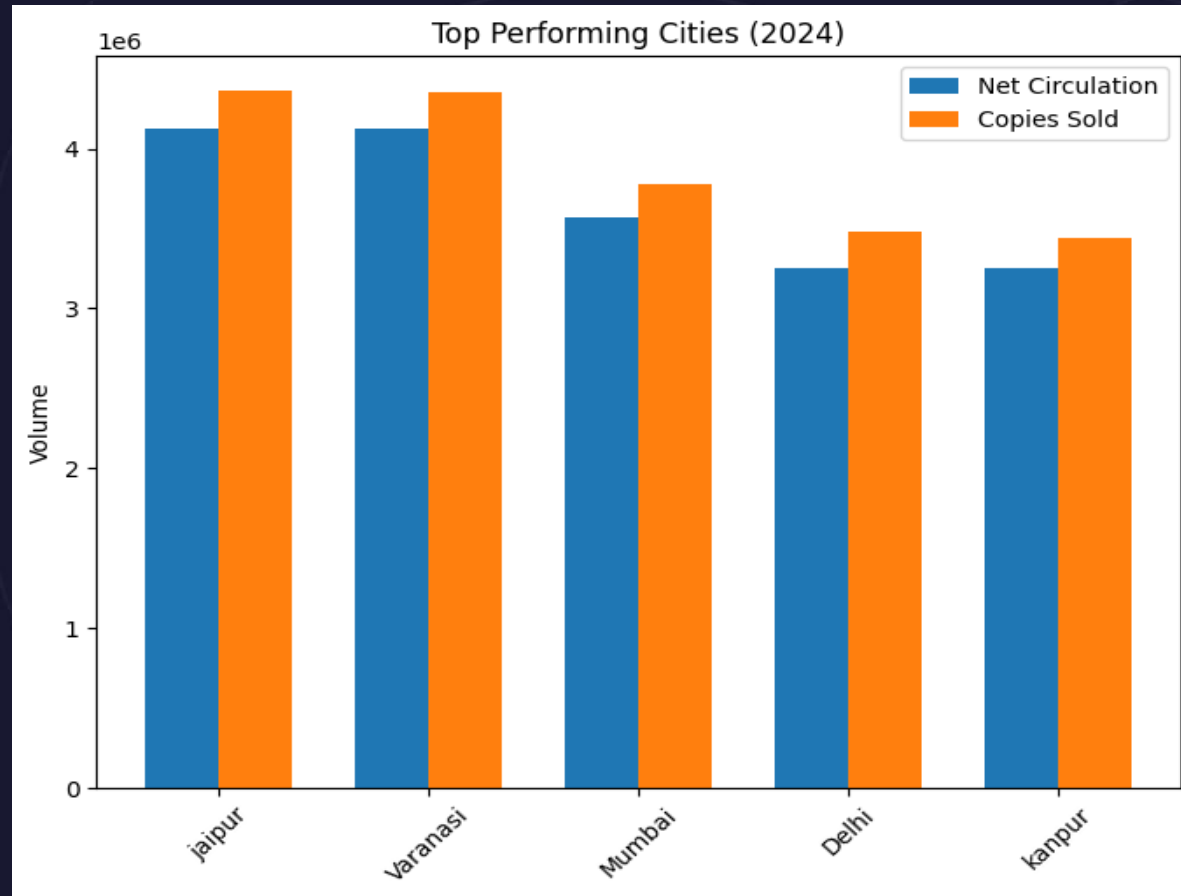
Once 1.2M daily copies, Multilingual, trusted regional journalism. Now circulation halved (2019–2024).



Circulation rose **170% from 240K in 2019 to 640K in 2020**, before falling **30% in 2021** to below 470K. This sharp swing shows how external shifts directly impact demand.

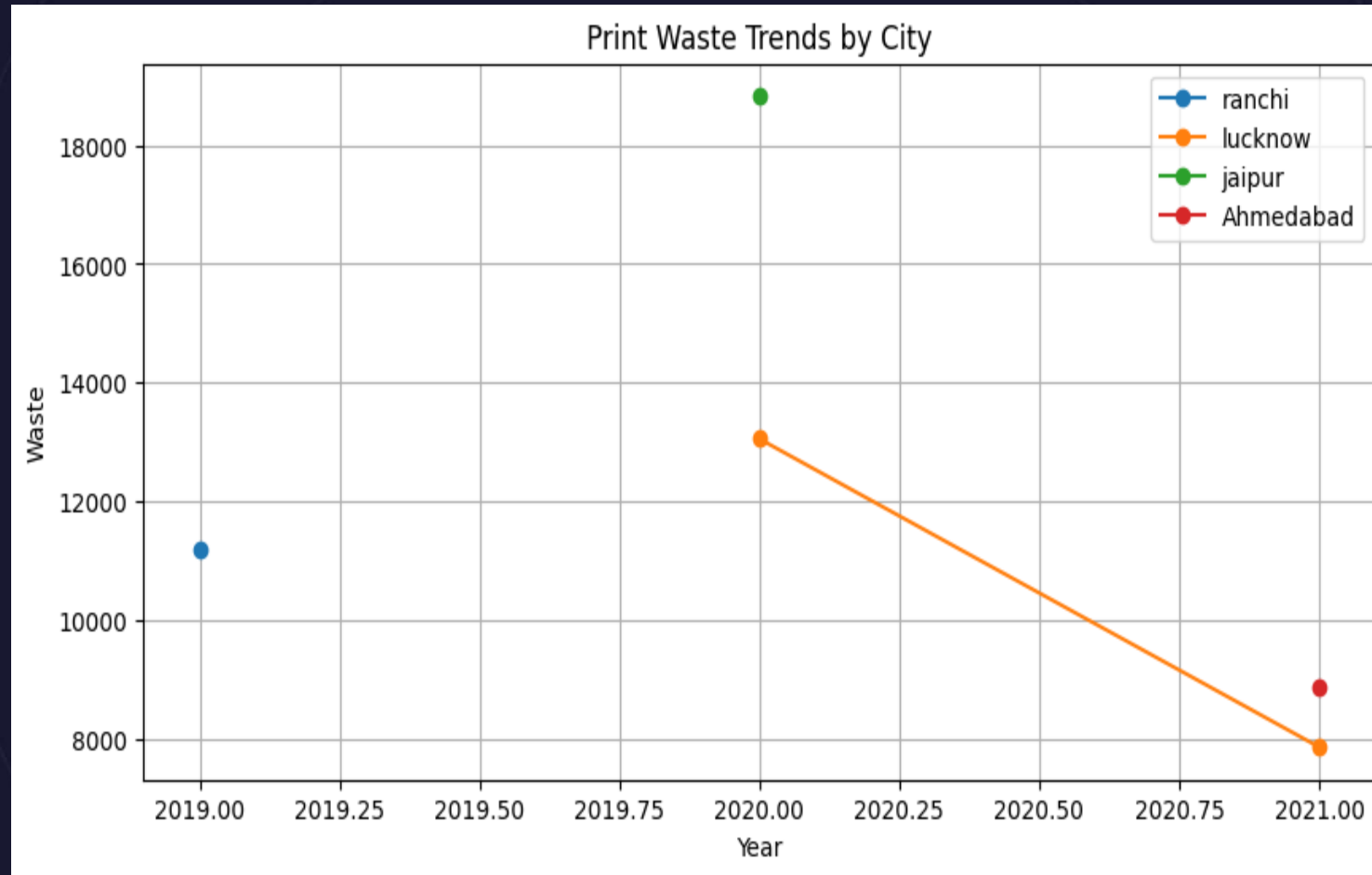
Print Performance

Even strong cities like Jaipur & Varanasi saw flat growth — overall circulation down”.



Jaipur and Varanasi dominate with **4.1M+ net circulation each (~24% share each)**, far ahead of Mumbai, Delhi, and Kanpur. They are the clear anchors of Bharat Herald's print market strength.

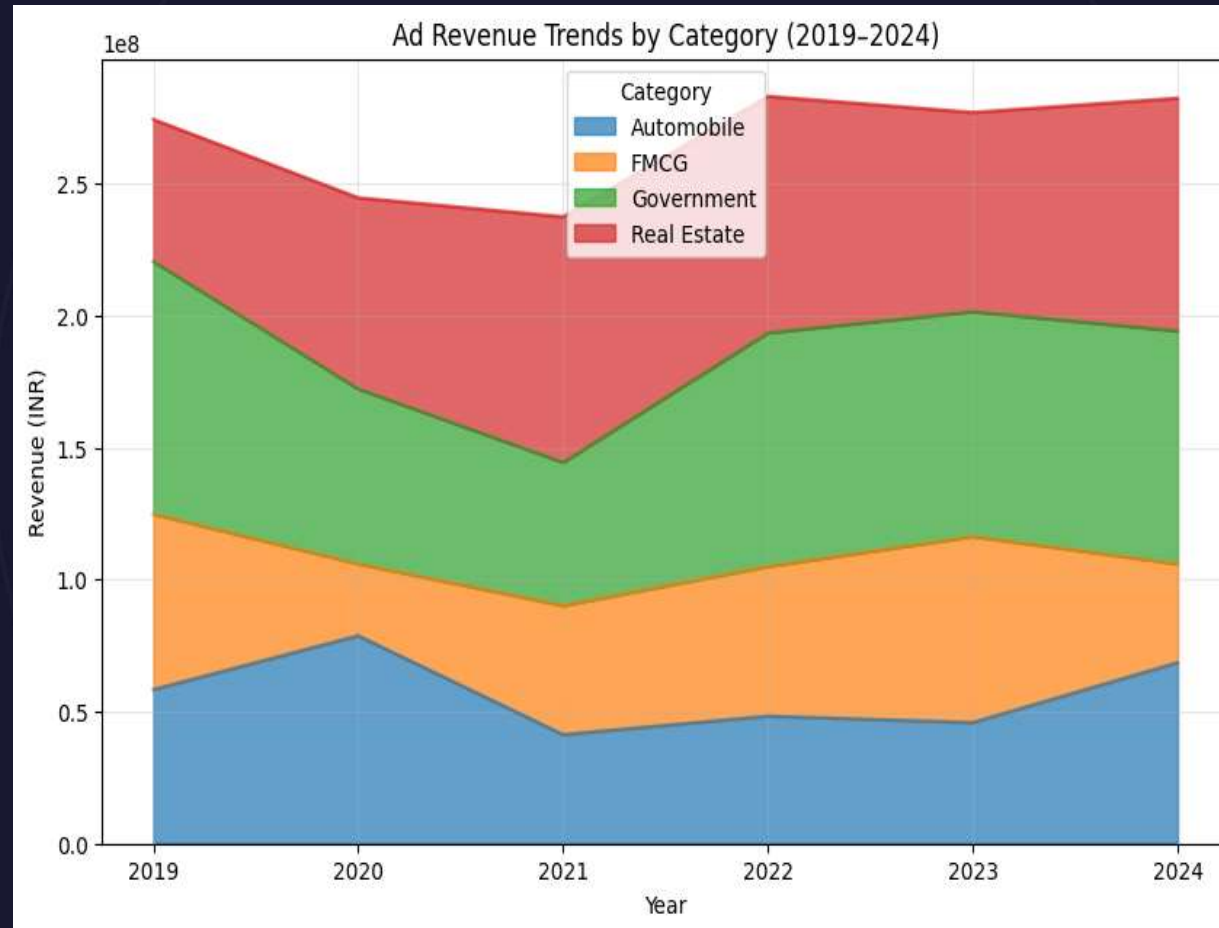
Operational Inefficiencies



Jaipur and Lucknow led waste in 2020 with **19K and 13K copies** respectively, but Lucknow cut waste by **38% in 2021**. This signals strong efficiency gains in select cities.

What Went Wrong (Overview)

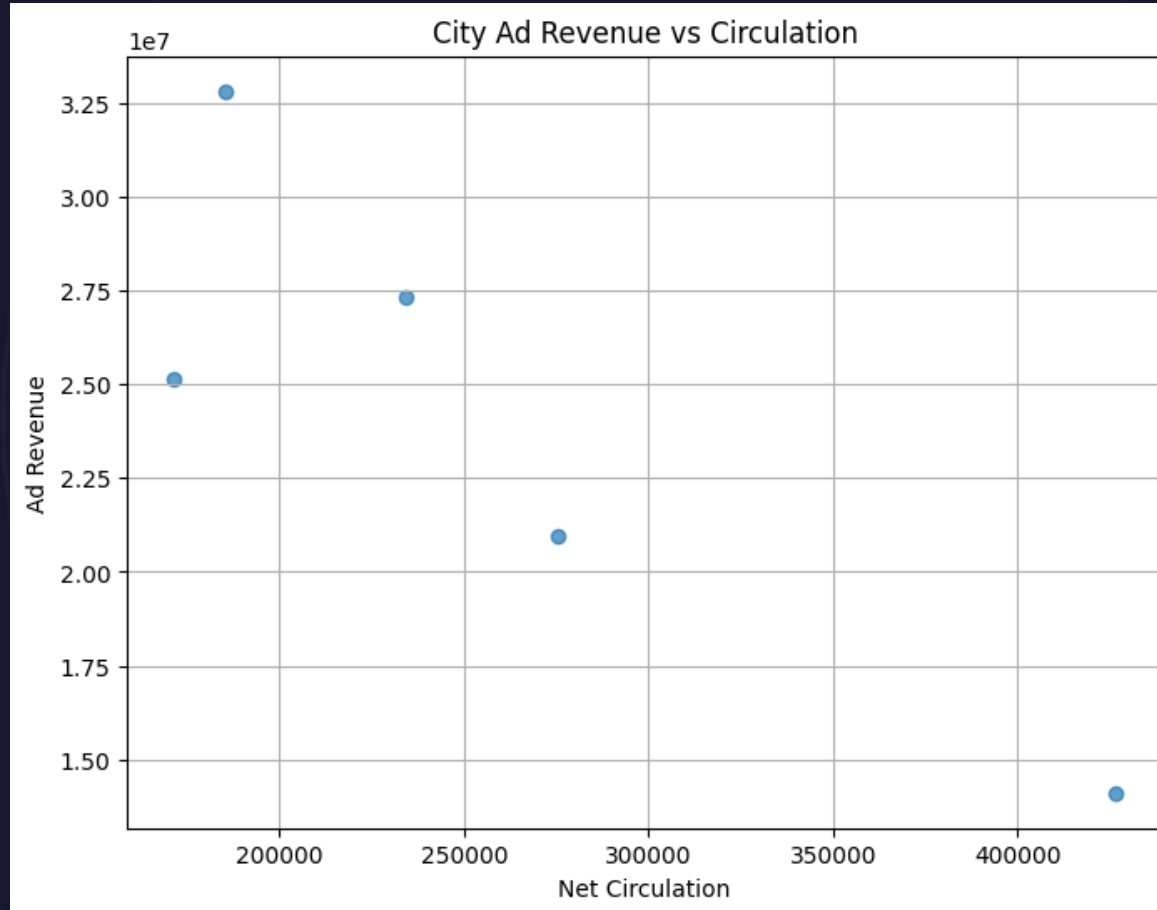
“Sharp volatility in FMCG & Automobile; Government ads declining post-2020”.



Real Estate and Government ads contribute 60%+ of revenues, averaging ₹1.0–1.3 crore annually.
Despite a dip in 2021, total ad revenue rebounded to ₹280M in 2024.

Recovery Potential

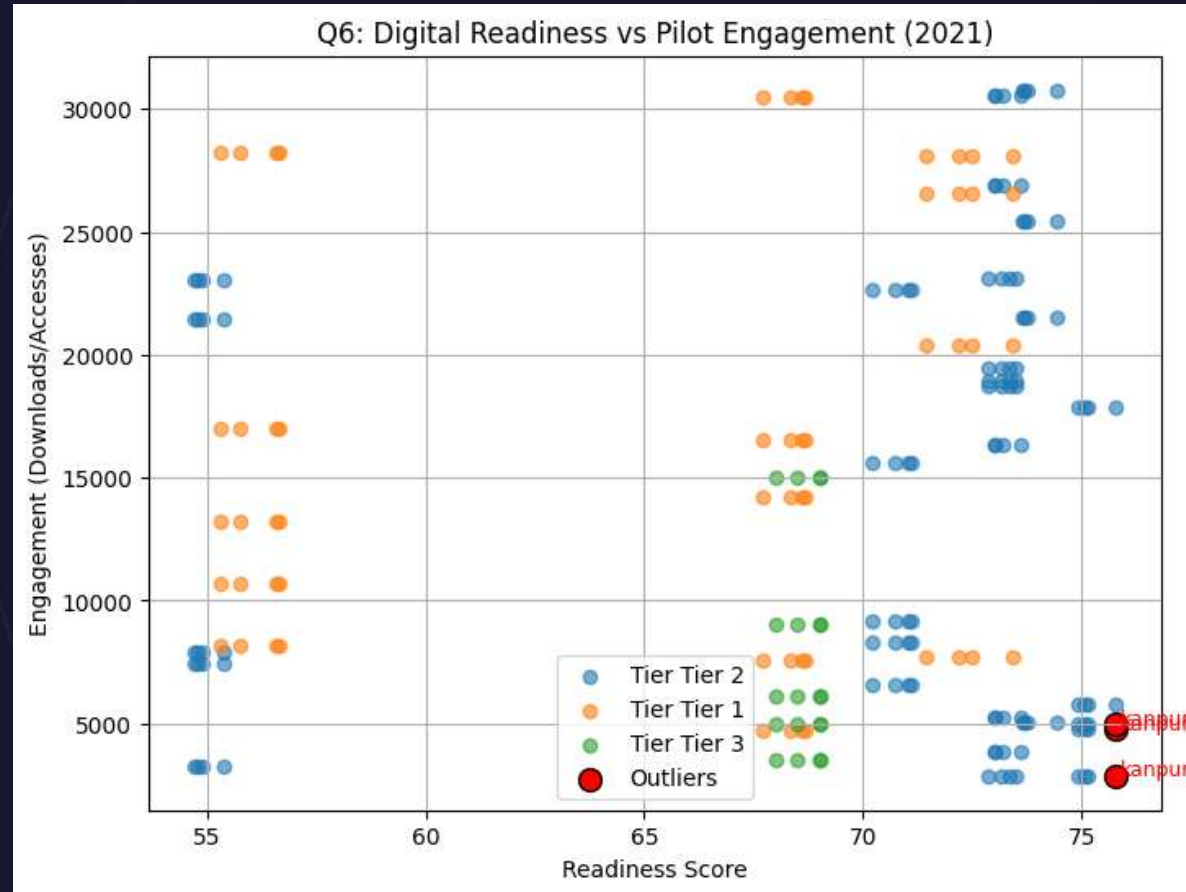
High ad revenue despite low circulation in some cities — digital-first opportunity”



Larger circulation does not guarantee higher ad income — a city with **420K copies** yields just **₹14M**, while smaller cities at **200K copies** earn up to **₹33M**. Some markets monetize circulation more effectively.

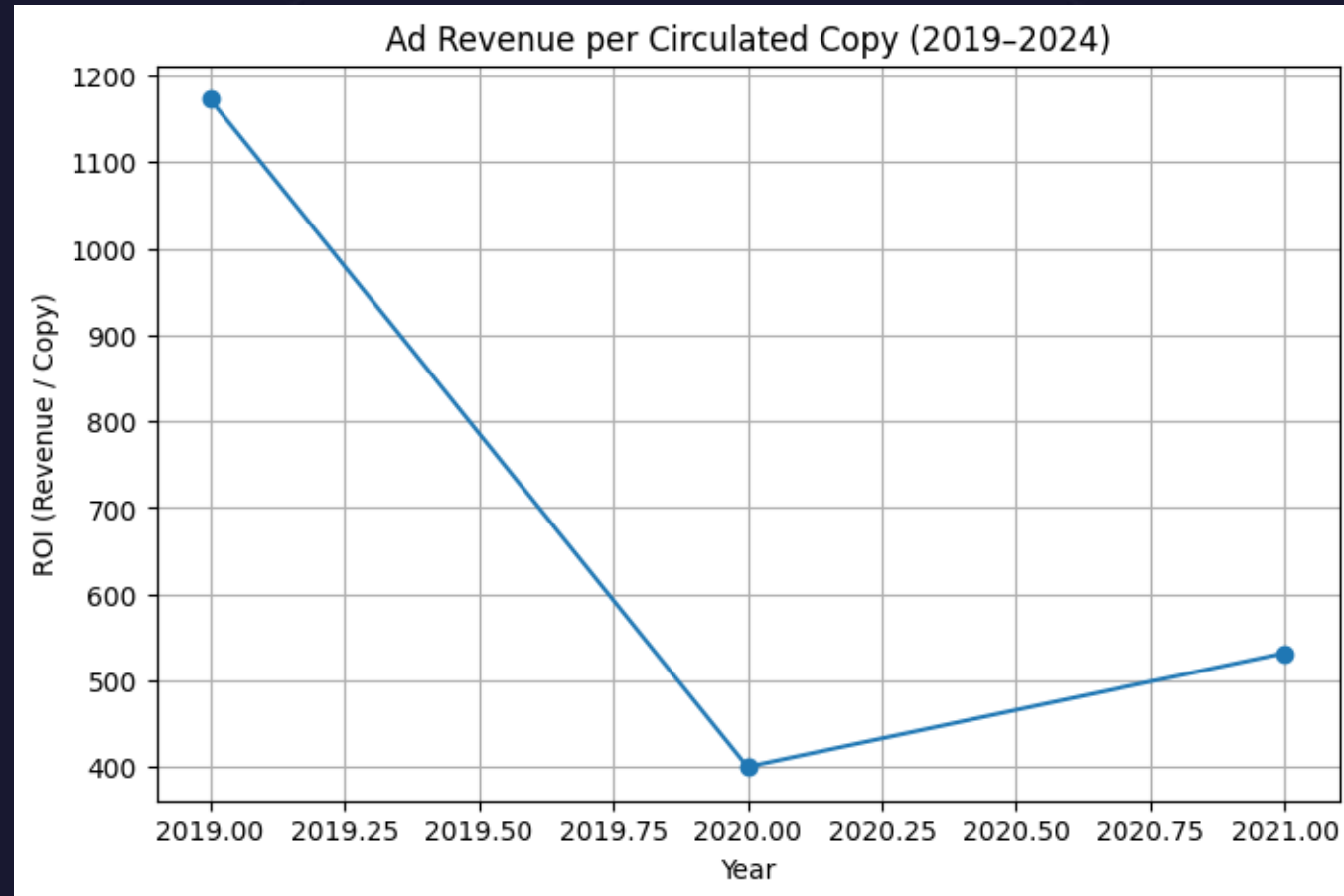
City Readiness vs Digital Pilot

Tier 1 cities showed readiness, but pilot engagement lagged — usability issues evident



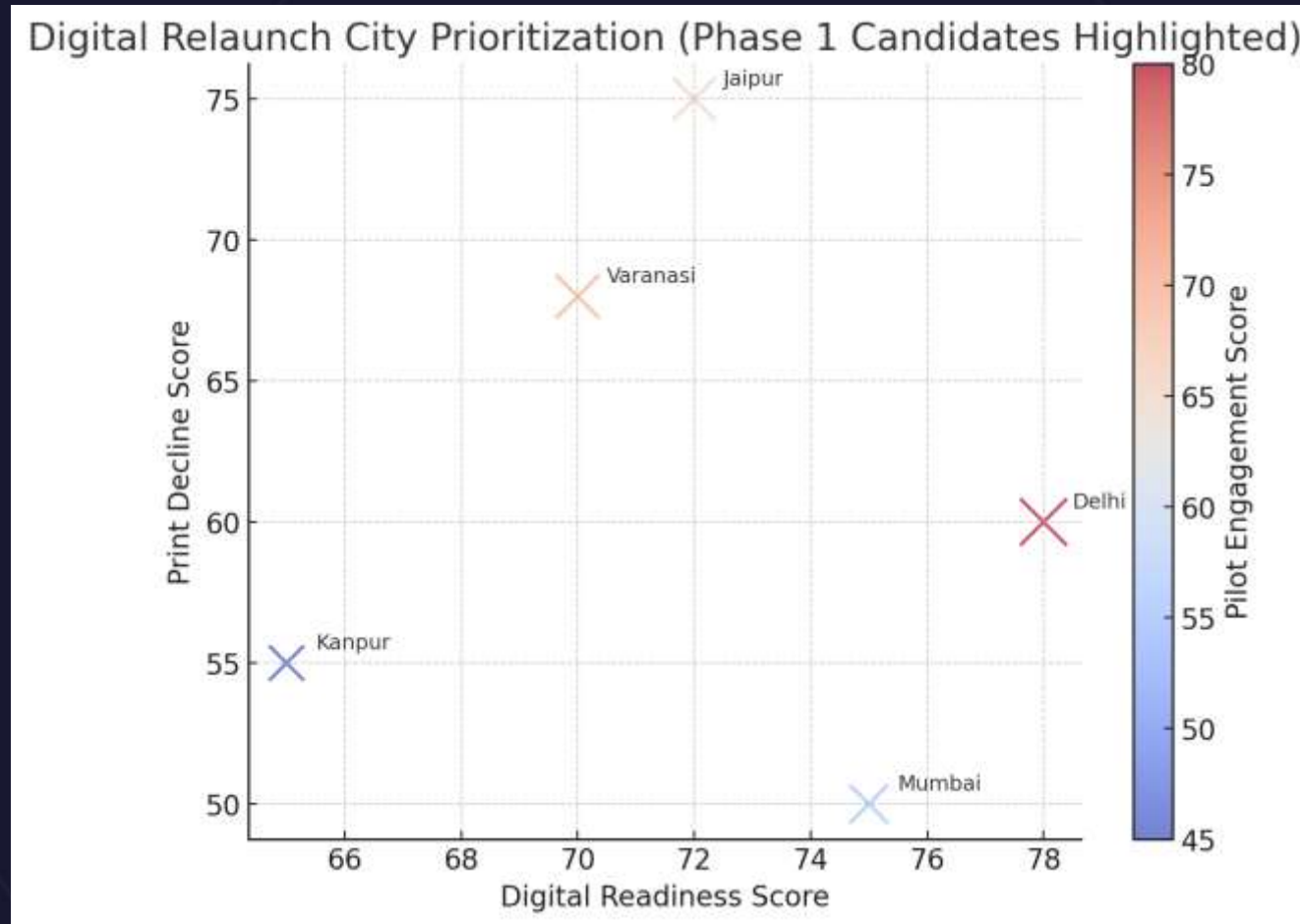
Several cities scored **70+ readiness**, but only a few converted to **20K+ downloads**. Kanpur is the key outlier — **75 readiness but under 6K engagement**, showing a usability gap.

Q7 - ROI per Copy



Efficiency dropped from **₹1,170 per copy in 2019** to **₹400 in 2020**, before a partial recovery to **₹550 in 2021**. This **65% decline** underscores the urgency of revenue diversification.

Digital Relaunch City Prioritization



Jaipur, Varanasi, and Delhi align highest on readiness (>70), print decline (>60), and pilot engagement (>60). These cities are best suited to lead Phase 1 of the digital relaunch.



Further analysis & recommendations:

From Print to Digital: A Phased Roadmap for Growth

“Staged rollout: Mobile-first pilots → Hybrid subscriptions → Multimedia expansion”

- **0–6 months:** Relaunch ultra-light WhatsApp-integrated ePaper in Jaipur, Varanasi, Delhi; benchmark vs. InShorts.
- **6–18 months:** Launch **print+digital bundles**, personalized newsletters, regional push alerts.
- **18–36 months:** Expand into **video, podcasts, AR/VR**, city-level events, and programmatic ads.

📊 *India's WhatsApp user base >500M → validates platform-first approach.*



Rebuilding Confidence in Key Markets

“Rebuild credibility with verified metrics & transparent reporting”

- Adopt **third-party audience audits** and monthly engagement dashboards.
 - Offer **native placements, sponsorships, and curated brand features**.
 - Run **co-branded community campaigns** and advertiser roundtables (Guardian model).
-  *Verified digital reporting can lift advertiser spend by 15–20% (PwC, 2023).*



WhatsApp, Video, Podcasts: Formats That Win

“Deliver snackable, regional, and interactive formats to drive engagement”

- **WhatsApp bulletins + 5-min daily updates** for mass reach.
 - Launch **regional podcasts/newsletters**; target Tier 2/3 with hyperlocal focus.
 - Experiment with **live events & gamified news** for younger audiences.
-  *InShorts grew to 10M+ users by focusing on 60-word news cards.*

Unlocking Revenue with Subscriptions & Loyalty



“Subscriptions + loyalty = sustainable revenue recovery”

- Deploy **tiered bundles**: free tier, premium content, micropayments.
- Roll out **family print+digital packages** for mid-income households.
- Launch **loyalty rewards** (discounts, exclusive invites, premium newsletters).
 *NYT & FT saw 10–25% digital revenue uplift via hybrid models.*



Community Storytelling as Bharat Herald's Edge

“Build trust via hyperlocal influencers & citizen journalism”

- Recruit **teachers, business owners, community leaders** as digital ambassadors.

- Create **citizen journalism fellowships** and regional contests.

- Elevate trusted journalists to anchor **local podcasts, livestreams, explainers.**

 *Local influencer tie-ups doubled engagement for US regional outlets (Reuters Institute, 2022).*

“PHASED DIGITAL RELAUNCH + ADVERTISER TRUST + REGIONAL AUTHENTICITY = RECOVERY”



- **Short term:** Fix usability, relaunch in high-readiness cities.
- **Mid term:** Blend print+digital, build personalized engagement.
- **Long term:** Expand into multimedia + community events.
- **Combine verified ad ROI + subscription innovation + local credibility** to execute a **36-month digital turnaround.**

